

SUNDAY, MARCH 14, 2004 | SECTION C **

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THE PLAIN DEALER



Wedge's work ethic stems from a throwback era

WINTER HAVEN, Fla.— The sounds from Eric Wedge's office after certain losses last season suggested more than one person inside.

Actually, the noise suggested a team of furniture movers.

Then the door would open to reveal Wedge all by his lonesome. Sometimes his uniform top occupied a randomly targeted corner. Cameras and micro-

BUD SHAW



phones would not capture that manager. They would get his guardedly calm twin Wedge standing perfectly still at his desk and delivering a postgame

analysis as dry as a calculus lecture.

"If I am going to have a moment," Wedge said Saturday, "it's going to be by myself."

Everything about the Indians' seriously organized manager has a particular form and function. Instead of flying, he drives to spring training because being on the road puts him in "a zone" and helps him think. Leave at 4 p.m. Saturday. Arrive 9 a.m. Sunday. Straight through.

"I got a message when he got there," General Manager Mark Shapiro said. "It said, 'I got it all figured out. I'm taking a nap. Call me in five hours.'"

A nap? Shapiro and Wedge share more than philosophies. They have synchronized their body clocks. The difference is Shapiro gets up at 4:30 a.m. and goes to the gym. Wedge skips that and arrives at his Chain of Lakes office by 6 a.m.

SEE SHAW | C6

More baseball

DIGGING IN: Pitcher Jason Bere is determined to make the team. C6

SECOND TO NONE: Second baseman Ronnie Belliard is impressing many on defense. C6

TALKING STEROIDS: A Players Association official says there's no need for a new testing program. C8

MAC TOURNAMENT



ROADELL HICKMAN | THE PLAIN DEALER

Western Michigan's Bobby Madison and other players scramble for a loose ball during the MAC Tournament title game Saturday night at Gund Arena.

Kent loses its touch; WMU grabs a title

Broncos' D smothers Edwards

When Kent State's players watched inspirational highlights of yesteryear before the Mid-American Conference Tournament began, former guard Trevor Huffman was probably the featured Flashdancer.

The players who followed him saw a long parade of game-winners and jubilation in the stands. Surely, that step-back jumper in 2001, which Huffman sank with Miami's Juby Johnson trailing him like a private eye with a perpetrator, was there.

It won the middle edition of Kent's three MAC Tournament titles in four years.



Bill Livingston

If Huffman wasn't the one everyone who played basketball at KSU wanted to be, his running mate Andrew Mitchell was. The clock would be ticking down and the bid to the Big Dance would be hanging in the balance, and all the hours in the gym, all the summers of coaxing blossoms from cracks in city playgrounds, would come down to one instant. He shoots, he scores.

Kent State had a lot of players who shot Saturday night, but not enough who scored in a 77-66 loss to Western Michigan in the MAC Tournament finals.

SEE LIVINGSTON | C15

COLLEGE BASKETBALL COVERAGE, C12-15

MAC CHAMPIONSHIPS

Men	Women
W. Michigan 77	E. Michigan 65
Kent State 66	BGSU 56

BIG TEN SEMIFINALS

Illinois 74	Wisconsin 68
Michigan 60	Michigan St. 66

JCU MAKES HISTORY: John Carroll men beat Wooster to reach the Final Four for the first time in school history. C13

TV: NCAA Tournament women's selection show, 5, ESPN; NCAA Tournament men's selection show, 6, WOIO Ch. 19.

ELTON ALEXANDER
Plain Dealer Reporter

The defense was good enough for Kent State to go to the NCAA Tournament. The offense was not, and it cost the Golden Flashes a chance at a MAC Tournament championship plus the trip to the big dance.

The Western Michigan Broncos, behind regular-season and MAC Tournament MVP Mike Williams, capped a sterling season with a 77-66 victory Saturday night at Gund Arena.

Williams did to Kent what the Flashes attempted to do to WMU: buried them with a game-winning 3-pointer with 54.7 seconds to play. It was his first trey of the season and capped a 28-point

night for the spindly 6-7 forward who did most of his work along the baseline and in the lane.

Holding a 66-62 lead and with the shot clock ticking down, Williams, well behind the line, lofted the 3-pointer that was true, sending a MAC team from Michigan to the NCAA Tournament for the second consecutive season. Last season, Central Michigan defeated Kent to join the field of 65.

"They made all the big plays," Kent State coach Jim Christian said. "Nineteen points off turnovers, 18 offensive rebounds. Give them credit, Anthony Kann [17 points, 12 rebounds] and Mike Williams, they made all the big plays."

SEE TITLE | C15

Carlisle finds NBA home

Pacers coach rides league merry-go-round to land in Indiana

MARY SCHMITT BOYER
Plain Dealer Reporter

The doors to the Gund Arena practice court were closed Saturday afternoon, but the sounds of clapping and singing could be heard clearly in the hallway.

Suddenly, the Indiana Pacers spilled out en masse, laughing and chatting as if they didn't have a care in the world.

Such is life when you have the best record in the NBA heading into this afternoon's game against the Cavaliers.

"It's always fun when you

Today

What: Cavaliers vs. Indiana.

When: 3 p.m.

Where: Gund Arena.

TV/radio: No television; WTAM AM/1100.

win," Pacers coach Rick Carlisle admitted.

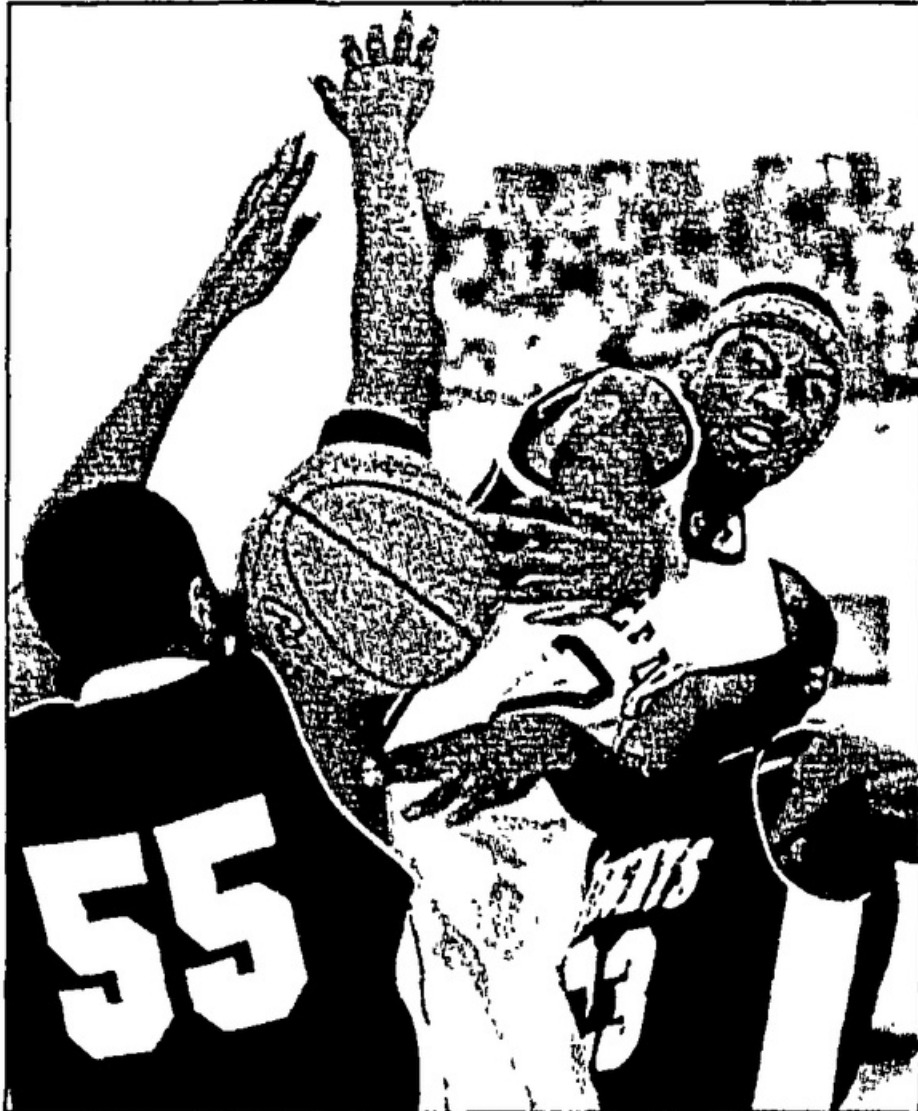
"That's one constant in this league. Obviously, we've done some good things and put ourselves in good position. But the goal continues to be to improve every day and prepare ourselves for playoff basketball and playoff success. That's going to be the

barometer of whether our season was successful or not."

The 44-year-old Carlisle found out the hard way that even a successful season — or two — might not be enough to prevent a coach from losing his job.

After joining Pat Riley as the only two coaches to win 50 games in their first two seasons, after winning Central Division titles in 2002 and 2003 and an NBA Coach of the Year award in 2002, Carlisle was fired by the Detroit Pistons after last season to make room for Larry Brown.

SEE COACH | C4



JOHN KUNTZ | THE PLAIN DEALER

HIGH SCHOOLS INSIDE

Ursuline brings an end to Regina's four-year reign

Regina's bid for a fifth straight state girls basketball title ends with a loss to Youngstown Ursuline in a regional final. C18

Olmsted Falls sends St. Ed home

Pat Braddick's 23 points lead the Bulldogs past the Eagles in a boys district final. C17

Bedford's Charles Osby wraps a pass around Cleveland Heights' Antoine Gray during the Bearcats' win in the Division I district final Saturday at South High School in Cleveland. Story, C18.